

# I love you. It'll pass: Death by Situationship

(Nana Toure)

The year is 2022, the day is, ironically, February 14th. High school, junior year. The scene is set in my bedroom, co-starting the mysterious new boy from Barcelona in the grade above whom the entire school had a crush on. The stakes are astronomical. We're playing the infamous We're Not Really Strangers game, and we're down to the last card. If you don't know the rules, the game asks you to write a note to your partner that you only read once you've parted ways. This comes after answering a series of questions separated into three levels and increasing in intimacy. I pick up one of the little red pencils provided in the kit, hand him the other, and we write in silence. The tension is heavy; we're pretending not to look at each other. He folds his note, I do the same, and we swap.

The second he leaves, I unfold mine at the speed of sound, my hands trembling. The first line is harmless enough: "I had a great time with you today, la la la." Then my eyes hit the bottom. In scrawny boy handwriting: "P.S. if you ever want to kiss, don't stop yourself." (Verbatim.)

I all but lost my mind. This was, at sixteen, the pinnacle of romance. When he came over again a week later, we were on the living room couch watching a poorly made Netflix original film, and, as was written in the stars, I went in for the kill. With hindsight being 20/20, I now refer to this event as the kiss of death. Unbeknownst to me, this was the start of my first "situationship." If you haven't heard the term before, count your blessings. Urban Dictionary defines a situationship as "less than a relationship but more than a booty call." Undefined, noncommittal, nauseating, a solution for loneliness for those with a disordered relationship with love that works until it doesn't.

He'd wink at me in the hallways. I'd take the long way to class to catch a glimpse of him. I was head over my Converse heels. Cloud 9 wasn't high enough, I could walk on water. I fell. Hard. I fell in love and scraped the skin off my knees.

It's at this point in the play that the "what are we" scene rolled around. After all, why weren't we dating? He was at my house every weekend, we'd fall asleep on the phone, he'd met my mother, you catch my drift. I asked the question, expecting a promise ring. He said: "*Oh, I just don't want a relationship.*" I was confused. I blinked stupidly. "*What do you mean?*" I asked. "*I just can't be anyone's boyfriend right now.*" he said as he stroked my hair and held my hand pretending to be my boyfriend. I felt pathetic. Still, I had to be cool, I couldn't lose him. What choice did I have? He wanted to keep things casual. How hard could that be? I could do casual...

Newsflash: I couldn't do casual.

I was hungry for love, and the crumbs he dropped were sickly sweet. I knew I was lactose intolerant and ate the pint of Häagen-Dazs anyway. Tune as old as song. Did I ignore my gut because he was tall, looked like Timothée Chalamet if you squinted, had brown curls that glowed like honey in the sunlight, smelled faintly of cinnamon, and was 16-year-old Nana's dream on legs? I invoke my Fifth Amendment right to remain silent. Being someone's dirty little secret was eating me alive. I wanted more, but I held my tongue so I could continue to hold his hands. Of course, the love affair left a scar. Like clockwork, we ended up strangers again.

The situationship. The best of times, the absolute worst of times. What is so virtuous about pretending you need nothing, rely on no one? Why is it so humiliating to tell someone what you want? The most cardinal sin to our generation is appearing burdensome. By forcing ourselves to appear nonchalant and disinterested in the name of being cool, we become ashamed of our own feelings. We may preserve our dignity at

the expense of experiencing another person who sees us as we are. In consequence, we've become actors in the stage play we've made of our lives, performing for an ever-present audience, so afraid of social missteps, another human being finding out we are not bulletproof. We move as if the world is watching, because in some ways, it is. The fear of being uncool, of letting our true thoughts show, is as easy to ignore as your sock sliding off in your shoe.

I worry that we are setting ourselves up to be one of the loneliest generations yet. We desperately want to be happy, but we don't know how to open ourselves up to it without it feeling like a humiliation ritual. We perform because we fear embarrassment, but is that not half of what love is? What allows us to save face in the moment leads us down a path to long-term frustration. The pursuit of romance tinged by the need to avoid pain at all costs is lonely. The annoying reality is that love cannot be found without opening yourself up to the risk of some suffering. We have decided en masse that avoiding heartbreak at all costs and rejection is more important than finding a partnership that lasts.

For years, I blamed myself for misplacing my affection, for giving my bleeding heart to someone who looked me in the eyes and told me he didn't want it. Cupid's famous arrow does not account for ricochets. Sometimes you aim wrong, sometimes it comes back to pierce you in your own heart. I felt the ache of both. I gave him enough love to fill the Pacific and swallowed enough saltwater to regret it.

Gen-Z wants to be in love, but we are afraid. Alas, complaining that the water is too cold does not change its temperature. The ocean doesn't negotiate, and the heart wants what it wants. Fortunately, though, I'm old enough now to know there is no use in allowing myself to sink when I know how to swim.

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